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THE SPOON INCIDENT



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I am perfect. I've never tasted an ounce of alcohol, never smoked a cigarette, never been late, missed class, or been sick. I have never got below an *A* on anything in my life. I always beat my friends at *Jeopardy*, and never use a life-line on *Who Wants to Be a Millionaire*. I have never been disciplined and have never had detention.

That was me about a month ago. Hi, I'm Peter McNamara and I'm not perfect anymore.

I'm a student at Morris P. Walters High School. We are the home of the ... well, our mascot is a ... we're the home of the Fighting Bunnies. Not the fighting hares, or fighting jack rabbits, or even the fighting cottontails. We, no *I,* am a Fighting Bunny.
The students, about a month ago, decided that we didn't want to be bunnies, but that we would rather be cougars, or lions, or even badgers, but not bunnies. So, we passed around a petition for all of the students to sign. Even part of the faculty laid down their Hancock. I didn't think that it would be a big deal; change the name and everyone's happy. Not the case. The superintendent called an assembly, and that was when I turned from an innocent sweet boy into the tainted monster that I am today.

Super: Ahem, students I've called you all here today to talk about our beloved Benny the Bunny. Our student body president has given me a signed petition with the intent of changing our mascot. This saddens me. What is not to love about our beloved Benny the Bunny? Is it his cute wiggly pink nose, cotton tail, big floppy ears? Is it his plush tummy?

Pete: This is where my persona took a turn towards Glen Close in *Fatal Attraction*. I had an evil thought as to a solution to the Benny the Bunny dilemma; Hasenpfeffer, a delicious German bunny dish.

Super: I have decided to decline your request for a change of mascot. Benny the Bunny will stay a fixture at Morris P. Walters High School and I will not hear another word about it.

Pete: In the words of the most famous bunny of them all, "Of course you realize, this means war."

I couldn't just flat out kidnap Benny. I didn't have the heart to harm him if our demands weren't met.. After all, Benny wasn't the enemy anymore, it was the Superintendent. My friends thought of a million ways to prank him. We could fill his car full of packing peanuts, or put baking flour in the vents of his car. We could super glue his office door shut, or put a picture of Fran the lunch lady over his wife's picture on his desk. We could have done some of the standard pranks like the bag of flaming dog pooh, or have his car towed, but these didn't make a statement. Then it hit me ... the lunch lady. The lunchroom. What could someone do to make a point? It was incredibly obvious. Hit the Superintendent where it hurts ... kick him square in the ... *(pause)* ... spoons.

Phase One: The kidnapping

It was a genius plan. We would take a hostage. Mission Impossible! Do Do Dooo, Do Do Dooo. I am Tom Cruise, I am a spy! Those spoons would have no chance. This was the plan: The mission would take a team of four. I needed recruits. I chose Butch Haden, the demolition's man. Wee Willie Brown, the human toothpick. Charles Alexander Kerr, the scapegoat. Not the most glamorous job, but his father is on the school board. And myself, the brains.

Objective one, the kitchen delivery door. The plan was to use the demolition man to precisely place M-80's around the hinges on the delivery door. This would weaken them so that we could use a sodium nitrate concentrate to finish the job. This would open the door just enough for, dun dun dun, the human toothpick. The toothpick squeezes in, and unlocks the door from the inside. Penetration complete. Next, we swipe the spoons and make our getaway. Genius! But, it did have some problems. No M-80's, no sodium nitrate, Willie had a urinary tract infection, and Charlie had bassoon lessons. Plan B was now in effect. Operation "Keep your dirty spoons after lunch and stash them in my locker." It was genius. Day by day, four spoons at a time my locker filled up. Other students caught wind of the plan and it took off like Benny the Bunny after some lettuce on a treadmill. 10 turned to 20 and 20 to 40. Soon school lunches cut back on their Jell-O from four days a week to only one. Macaroni and cheese was replaced by corn bread, and so on and so forth. The school began to panic. TOTAL DISMAY! We had to prove to the Superintendent that it was affecting us students, so we did a little acting.

Pete: What!? No spoons!? No Jell-O!? No macaroni and cheese!? Why!? WHY!? What have we done to deserve this torture? I NEED MY MACARONI AND CHEESE! *(Off to side)* The seed had been planted.

Phase Two: The uprising

After my Oscar performance we made it clear that the student body was upset. We picketed the school lunch program. They tried to give us plastic sporks, but we had none of that.

Pete: We want our spoons back!

Super: Students, listen. Until we find out what happened to all of our spoons, you'll have to make due.

Pete: I poked my tongue on one of those misshaped- hybrid sporks. *(Looking around and chanting)* We want spoons. We want spoons... *(To the side)* Two for the crew.

Phase Three: The hostage letter

I, being a perfect student, did the morning announcements. The previous night "the crew" and I made a hostage request.

It read:

> We are the coalition for the request ensuring equality in the population of students. Or the C.R.E.E.P.S. for short. We the Creeps have your beloved spoons. We will make sure that the spoons are unharmed in exchange for changing our mascot. For every hour that our demands are not met, five spoons will be bent. You have only to three o'clock to decide.
>
> Signed, *The Creeps*.

After the announcement the principal called me into his office. I knew I was screwed. The Superintendent was standing there with a box full of spoons.

Pete: I can explain!

Super: No need Peter, we heard the announcement. But, we don't have to worry about the C.R.E.E.P.S ... now do we?

Pete: How did you find out?

I thought for sure that we could pull it off; that we wouldn't be caught. My only thought was that one of the masses must have turned us in for brownie points. They couldn't do this! My plan was fool proof. No faults, I was perfect! I couldn't get in trouble. Oh man, the guys were going to kill me. Defeat! Total and utter defeat.

Super: Peter ... Tell me what you know ... about Lunch Lady Fran.

Pete: Lunch Lady Fran?

What the ... Lunch Lady Fran? I didn't get it. He thought that lunch lady Fran was the C.R.E.E.P.S. Which come to think of it, she was a lot of the time.

> Evil. Pure and simple. No soul either. Vile, vile woman. I heard that she made a pact with Lucifer himself. Heard that she spits in the soup and puts *Exlax* in the brownies. She's gotta go. Why? Do you think she took the spoons? Get her. Make her pay. Teach that nasty human a lesson.

Super: Now, Peter. Be fair. We don't know anything for sure. What I do know are the spoons I'm holding are the only ones left. We are going to lock them away in here until this thing is resolved.

Pete: Don't worry, I'm on it.

I bolted from that office before the Superintendent had a chance to stop me. This was awful, now all of our hard work was being credited to that old, nasty, wrinkled, toothless, hairless, prune skinned Lunch Lady Fran. THIS SUCKED Our demands would never be met and the lunch lady was toast. No pun intended. And I was doomed to be a Fighting Bunny. But then ... we caught a break.

Lunch Lady Fran left that afternoon for a two-week ladle convention. All we had to do was prove our moxie. In another genius thought, I devised how we could reclaim the credit. The 3:00 p.m. deadline would start the ball in motion with the mutilation of five spoons. Then that evening we would break into the office and claim the remaining booty. Lunch Lady Fran was out of town with an iron clad alibi so she would be cleared of any suspicion. And the C.R.E.E.P.S would be taken seriously again. I reassembled the team during lunch. Bad luck and sudden case of mono left us without Charles Alexander Kerr, the scapegoat. Since there were no spoons to be had at lunch I smuggled five of the hostages in my book bag. As I unzipped the top the three of us peered in. They were pathetic laying silently side-by-side. We were pathetic standing side-by-side feeling remorse for the inanimate objects. Wee Willy was the first to break the silence.

Wee: No way I'm doing anything to them. They're like a family of somethin'

Wee was known for being squeamish. That was part of why he was "The human toothpick", most food repulsed him.

Pete: Don't be such a skirt, we're talking about spoons here. Butch, can you handle it?

Now I figured this was right up his alley. I could see him creating some hideous concoction which would dissolve the hostages into a molten goo. But, I was wrong.

Butch: No can do dude. I'm with Wee. They just look so....sad.

Pete: You've got to be kidding me. Aren't you the guy who turned a toad inside out with a Blackcat? The same kid who burned ants by the thousands with your magnifying glass? Am I talking to the same kid!?

Butch: That was different dude, they were in the wild. They had a chance. These guys are trapped.

Pete: GUYS!? GUYS!? THEY ARE NOT GUYS THEY ARE SPOONS!!!!!

I guess I said it a bit too loud as every head was now turned in my direction. It was so quiet I could pinpoint the author of a distant silent fart in the north end of the lunchroom. I quickly rebounded.

Pete: SPOONS! SPOONS! SPOONS! WE WANT SPOONS!

Soon the whole room was a cacophony of chants. I was Gipetto moving about the weak-minded puppets. The task would fall to me. I zipped up my bag and made a hasty exit unnoticed by the swarming mob.

The last two classes crept by as I waited for the announcement from the Super telling us that the mascot had been changed. At 2:45 I asked the teacher to be excused to use the restroom. She nodded her head without even looking up. Once in the boy's room I made my way to the far end stall, shutting and locking the door. This was the moment of truth, it was obvious that the administration was going to play hardball. Five hostages would have to be sacrificed in order to make them understand that the C.R.E.E.P.S meant business. I opened my book-bag and without looking, reached inside to grab the five of them. They were cold to the touch. Fear perhaps. I shut the lid to the stool and placed them shoulder to shoulder, face down. I paused a moment, a long moment. My brain was swirling in indecision. Was I really a monster who could do something like this? What are you talking about? They are just spoons! They? You said they. I meant.....I don't know what I meant. I picked one up and turned it over and held it close. I could see my own face reflecting back at me on the head of the spoon. I smiled and the spoon smiled back. I tore me up inside. I, in a last ditch effort to carry out the deed, pulled the spoon away and gripped it at both ends within clenched fists. I closed my eyes
and started to bend. The spoon fought me, not willing to give up without a fight. As I changed position to apply more force, my knee bumped the lid and two of the spoons fell to the ground. The high-pitched screams from their collision with the concrete floor startled me. One managed to scamper to the next stall in a blatant escape attempt. I looked down at my hands. Without even being aware, I had bent the spoon. He hung limp across my index finger. I felt horrible. I quickly tried to undo my heinous act. But as hard as I tried, I couldn't make it right. The poor guy was just not the same. The small hump midway up his neck mocked me as a reminder of what I had done. I realized I too was changed. Never again would I be the perfect, innocent young man that I was. As hard as I tried from here on out to regain my former self, there would always be a small hump in my character.

Defeated, I retrieved the five spoons and made my way to my locker. I opened it and filled my bag with all of the hostages before heading to the principal's office. In a flurry of confession, I spilled my guts along with the contents of my bag. When all was said and done, I was expelled for two days and not allowed to be issued a spoon during lunch for the remainder of the year. My accomplices were left out of my story. I alone bore the shame of what I had done. In the end I realize also that our mascot was probably an accurate representative for me and my friends. We really were, Fighting Bunnies.

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